maritime security initiative for Southeast Asia, designed to help build capacity among nations in the world's most congested waterways. Abe has in particular formed a close relationship with Prime Minister Narendra Modi of India, discussing a strategic partnership between Asia's most powerful democracies that could be seen as a gambit to counter Chinese hegemony in the region.

If Tokyo has attempted to build bridges to Asian nations in a cooperative gamble, Beijing has staked out a more hegemonic position in trying to change the balance of power in the region. China has built an overwhelming military force, consisting of the world's largest navy, advanced fighter jets, ballistic missiles, and space and cyber capabilities. In the South China Sea, it has constructed and militarized artificial islands in an attempt to be the dominant power in the world's most vital waters.

China faces a more complicated security equation in Asia than Japan does, given its assertive claims in the East and South China Seas, and its territorial disputes with many of its neighbors, including large nations such as India. The dramatic growth of China's military over the past two decades has resulted not merely in a more capable navy and air force but in policies designed to defend and even extend its claims. The high-profile land reclamation and construction of bases in the Spratly Island chain exemplify Beijing's decision to assert its various claims and back them up with a military presence that dwarfs those of other contestant nations in the South China Sea. Similarly, the increase in Chinese maritime exercises in areas far from its claimed territory, such as the James Shoal, near Malaysia, or in the Indian Ocean, has worried nations that see Beijing's increasing capabilities as a potential threat.

China has, of course, attempted to assuage these concerns through maritime diplomacy, such as engaging in an ongoing set of negotiations with ASEAN nations over a code of conduct in the South China Sea, or conducting joint exercises with Malaysia. Yet repeated acts of intimidation and direct warnings to Asian nations have blunted any goodwill, forcing smaller states to consider how far to acquiesce in China's expansionist activities. Small nations in the region well